

But not by much! On the one hand, we were lucky to see a growth pattern that started to look like the famous hockey stick graph. On the other hand, the graph went up only to a few thousand dollars per month. These early graphs, although promising, were not by themselves sufficient to combat the loss of faith caused by our early failure, and we lacked the language of validated learning to provide an alternative concept to rally around. We were quite fortunate that some of our early investors understood its importance and were willing to look beyond our small gross numbers to see the real progress we were making. (You'll see the exact same graphs they did in [Chapter 7](#).)

Thus, we can mitigate the waste that happens because of the audacity of zero with validated learning. What we needed to demonstrate was that our product development efforts were leading us toward massive success without giving in to the temptation to fall back on vanity metrics and “success theater”—the work we do to make ourselves look successful. We could have tried marketing gimmicks, bought a Super Bowl ad, or tried flamboyant public relations (PR) as a way of juicing our gross numbers. That would have given investors the illusion of traction, but only for a short time. Eventually, the fundamentals of the business would win out and the PR bump would pass. Because we would have squandered precious resources on theatrics instead of progress, we would have been in real trouble.

Sixty million avatars later, IMVU is still going strong. Its legacy is not just a great product, an amazing team, and promising financial results but a whole new way of measuring the progress of startups.

LESSONS BEYOND IMVU

I have had many opportunities to teach the IMVU story as a business case ever since Stanford's Graduate School of Business wrote an official study about IMVU's early years.⁵ The case is now part of the entrepreneurship curriculum at several business schools, including Harvard Business School, where I serve as an